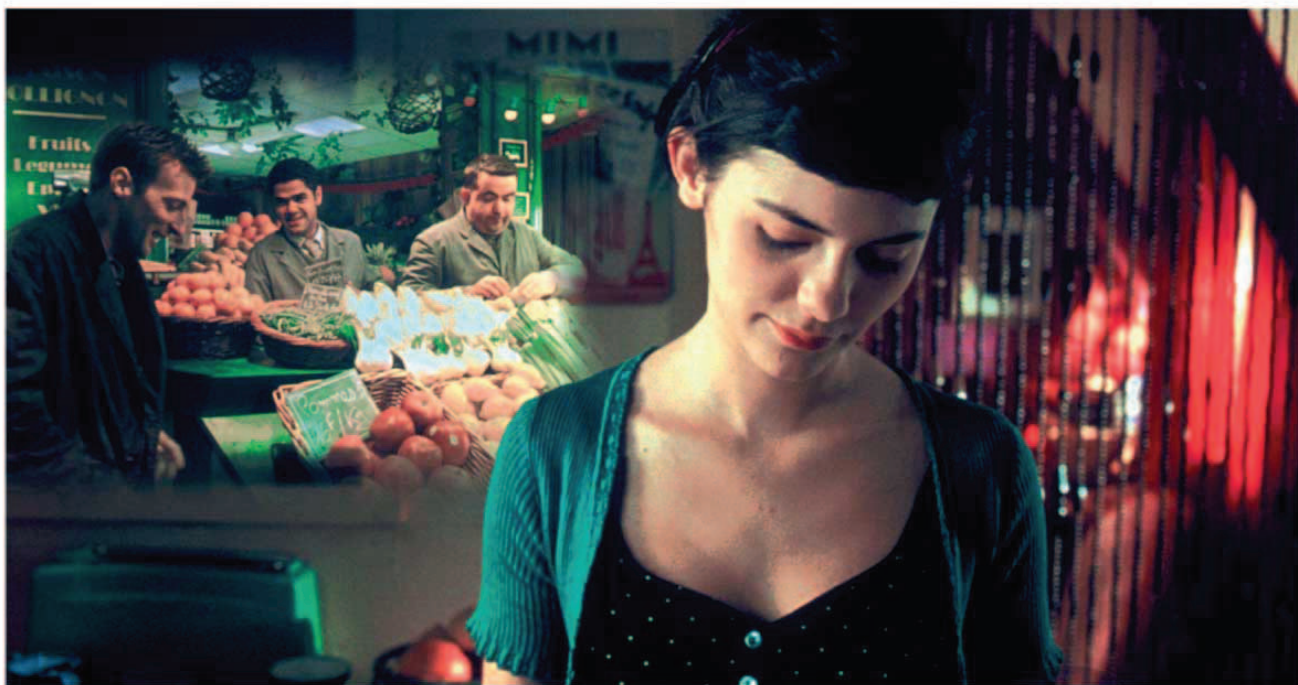


What else to watch: *Funny Face* (1957) ■ *The Umbrellas of Cherbourg* (1964, p.173) ■ *Delicatessen* (1991) ■ *The City of Lost Children* (1995) ■ *Alien: Resurrection* (1997) ■ *A Very Long Engagement* (2004)



techniques all serve as platforms for the director's skill without losing touch with an intimate story: that of a young woman finding herself.

Saying without words

Amélie has a very pronounced visual showmanship, which underscores one of the movie's key themes—that the most valuable communication is done without words. Its central protagonist, the young waitress Amélie, is so shy that she plots elaborate ways to convey things she is incapable of putting into words. For example, instead of confronting a shop owner she sees abusing his employee, she subtly disrupts the owner's daily

routine to the point where he doubts his own sanity, such as by swapping around door handles in his apartment and changing the alarm time on his bedside clock. By the same token, when she tries to reignite her father's dream of seeing the world, she does so by "kidnapping" his garden gnome and sending her father photos of it appearing in several exotic locations. These are disparate goals. One is an act of social vigilantism, the other a familial gesture of love. Yet Amélie goes about both in the same way, manipulating reality to get the person to the place she wants them—not out of malice, but

Amélie (Audrey Tautou) plays jokes on the bullying grocery-store owner (Urbain Cancelier) for his cruelty to Lucien (Jamel Debbouze). She secretly falls for Nino (Mathieu Kassovitz, far left).

because she sees the world in a different way. She notices things other people don't and acts in a way other people would not. This is especially so when Amélie finds herself face to face with her love interest, Nino. There is no speech of any kind. They simply look at each other, seeing into the person honestly, and realize they are meant for each other.

Though some criticized *Amélie* for what was seen as a dated portrait of Paris, others fell in love with the way it merges ambition with soulfulness, juxtaposing high-energy visuals and narrative adventure with the simple story of a boy and a girl falling in love. ■

“She doesn't relate to people, she was always a lonely child.”

Amélie / Amélie